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Fire Departments Begin $3.2 Million Wildfire Prevention Project in Santa Monica Mountains

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Los Angeles and Ventura county fire departments launched a major wildfire prevention initiative Monday in the Santa Monica Mountains, deploying hand crews and 500 goats to clear hazardous vegetation from 674.6 acres of parkland and open space.

The $3.2 million project, funded through Proposition 4 bonds allocated by the Santa Monica Mountains Conservancy, targets high-risk areas in Topanga Canyon and Upper Las Virgenes Canyon Open Space Preserve. The initiative comes eight months after devastating wildfires swept through Southern California, including the Palisades, Eaton and Kenneth fires that underscored the urgent need for proactive fire prevention measures.

Los Angeles County Fire hand crews began clearing vegetation Monday along Santa Maria Road and Mulholland Drive in Topanga, with work continuing to Summit to Summit Motorway. Next Wednesday, 500 goats will arrive at Upper Las Virgenes Canyon Open Space Preserve for approximately three weeks of brush clearing before moving to the next treatment location.

"This grant is a critical investment in the safety of our communities," said Ventura County Fire Chief Dustin Gardner. "It is a forward-looking, community-centered approach that addresses immediate risks and long-term resilience."

The Mountains Recreation and Conservation Authority is leading the fuel reduction efforts in partnership with both fire departments through the Statewide Fuels Reduction Environmental Protection Plan. The project aims to create strategic defensible space around communities including Topanga, Malibu, Calabasas and Agoura Hills.

"Fire prevention is a year-round activity for the MRCA," said Ken Nelson, MRCA Chief Fire Management Officer. "With lower-than-average rainfall and warmer weather, fire season is, unfortunately, already upon us."

The use of goats represents a shift toward more sustainable land management practices. Los Angeles County Assistant Fire Chief Drew Smith explained that while mechanical hand crews have maintained these areas in the past, the fire department is now utilizing more environmentally friendly methods.

"With proper land management practices, we can help mitigate the risk of wildfire while also preserving the environment and protecting life and property," Smith said.

The funding comes from Proposition 4, approved by voters in November 2024, which allocated $31 million to the Santa Monica Mountains Conservancy for watershed improvement, wildfire resilience and habitat restoration. The Legislature fast-tracked the program through Assembly Bill 100, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel and signed by Governor Newsom in April.

"In less than two weeks the Conservancy has granted funds and begun to put extensive preventative management strategies in place before the next fire season," said Steve Veres, Santa Monica Mountains Conservancy chairperson. "We will move quickly and fund the entities who will most effectively protect our communities now."

High-intensity wildfires have become increasingly common in the Santa Monica Mountains, driven primarily by Santa Ana and sundowner winds. The January 2025 fires highlighted the growing severity of fire seasons in Southern California and the critical need for year-round prevention efforts.

Environmental consulting firm Dudek completed biological surveys and flagging for sensitive species last week, while Native American tribal monitoring will be present at each location. Los Angeles County will provide an on-site

professional forester to monitor the projects.

Ventura County Supervisor Jeff Gorell emphasized the collaborative nature of the effort. "This funding is vital for ongoing efforts to protect our region from the growing threat of wildfire," he said. "It builds on the strong foundation laid by the Ventura County Fire Department and our community partners."

The MRCA and Conservancy have preserved more than 75,000 acres of local open space and habitat and are active members of the Santa Monica Mountains Fire Safe Alliance, an umbrella group convened by Los Angeles County Supervisor Lindsay Horvath.

The $3.2 million grants represent the first of many awards the Conservancy plans to distribute from Proposition 4 funds for wildfire prevention and climate resilience efforts.

Updated project information is available at https://mrca.ca.gov/statewide-critical-fuel-reduction-projects/.

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